

Information on Unconscious Bias

How hidden assumptions can influence risk assessment in child welfare

What is Unconscious Bias?

- Automatic assumptions made without awareness
- Shaped by experiences and stereotypes
- Can influence decisions even when trying to be fair



Why it Matters

- Influences how risk is interpreted
- May lead to:
 - Overestimating risk for some youth
 - Missing risk in others
- Particularly relevant for:
 - Racialized youth
 - Indigenous youth



How Bias Shows Up

- “This youth seems risky” → based on appearance
- The same behaviour is judged differently across youth
- Assumptions about intent without evidence
- Relying on “gut feeling” over information



What You Can Do

- Pause before making decisions
- Ask: “What evidence supports this?”
- Consider alternative explanations
- Reflect on patterns in your judgements
- Consult with colleagues when unsure



References

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